TALK FIVE

5 The Cup

"The cup which my Father hath given me, shall I not drink it?"

JOHN 18:11

When Jesus began telling His disciples what would happen to Him in Jerusalem, Peter did not want to hear it. Matthew says Jesus explained that He would suffer, be killed, and rise again the third day. Peter took Him aside and insisted that this must not happen to Him. Jesus answered, "Get thee behind me, Satan." That is a hard answer to someone who wanted to protect Him. But Peter was urging Jesus away from the work He had come to do. Jesus recognized the temptation even when it came in the voice of a friend.

Jesus had agreed before His birth to atone for the sins of the world. In the council in heaven, He answered the Father, "Father, thy will be done, and the glory be thine forever." Keeping that promise required a body. Jesus would have to live a mortal life, suffer, and offer His life for us. Hebrews connects His coming to earth with that purpose: "A body hast thou prepared me," and, "I come … to do thy will, O God." The body He received made it possible for Him to carry out what He had promised.

Jesus called the suffering ahead of Him a cup He would drink. When the mother of James and John asked for her sons to sit beside Him in His kingdom, Jesus asked whether they could drink His cup. They answered, "We are able." They wanted to be beside Him in glory, but they did not yet understand the suffering He was talking about, and they had not covenanted with the Father to do it.

Jesus understood, and the Gospels show how heavily that knowledge weighed on Him. Luke says that "he steadfastly set his face to go to Jerusalem." Jesus was going there deliberately, knowing what would happen. He told His disciples, "I have a baptism to be baptized with; and how am I straitened till it be accomplished!" *Straitened* means pressed or constrained. He felt the weight of what was coming before it happened. A few days before

His death, He said, “Now is my soul troubled.” He spoke of asking the Father to save Him from that hour, then said, “But for this cause came I unto this hour.” The thing that troubled Him was also the thing He had come to do.

On the night before His death, Jesus went to Gethsemane. Matthew records that He prayed a second time, saying, in the New Living Translation, “My Father! If this cup cannot be taken away unless I drink it, your will be done.” Jesus understood that fulfilling the Father’s will meant drinking the cup Himself. In the council, He had said, “Thy will be done.” Now He said it again while suffering in a mortal body.

That willingness did not make the suffering easy. In section 19, Jesus tells us how much He wanted relief. The pain caused Him “to tremble,” “to bleed at every pore,” and “to suffer both body and spirit.” He calls His suffering “the bitter cup” and says He wished He might not drink it. Then He tells us what He chose: “Nevertheless, glory be to the Father, and I partook.” He endured the suffering He had asked to have removed. Sometimes we picture His obedience as though He went through that night calm and untroubled. His own words tell us otherwise.

Jesus had already made the promise. In the garden, He had to keep it. Before coming to earth, He had never lived in a mortal body. Now He was suffering in both body and spirit, and He still chose the Father’s will. I believe He could have refused. His earlier promise did not take away His agency or make that night easy.

But refusing the cup could not accomplish what drinking it would. The Father had promised His children resurrection and a way to repent and be forgiven. Those promises required an Atonement. John Taylor explains that the law required the sacrifice, so the cup could not simply be taken away and the Father’s purpose still be fulfilled. “The Father did not let it pass from Him,” he wrote. “He therefore drank it.” Jesus was free to choose, but there was no way to save us without the sacrifice He had agreed to make. Luke tells us that an angel came from heaven and strengthened Him. The suffering remained, and Jesus received help to endure it.

When the men came to arrest Jesus later that night, Peter again tried to stop what was happening. This time he drew a sword and struck one of them. Earlier, Peter had argued that Jesus must not suffer. Now he was fighting to prevent it. Jesus told him to put the sword away and asked, "The cup which my Father hath given me, shall I not drink it?" Peter wanted to rescue Jesus from the thing Jesus had promised to do for him—and for all of us.

After His resurrection, Jesus told the Nephites, "I have drunk out of that bitter cup which the Father hath given me." He said He had "suffered the will of the Father in all things from the beginning." *Suffered* here means allowed. That takes us back to the council and the promise He made there. He had carried out the Father's will through His mortal life.

I can understand Peter's wish to protect Him. I would not want someone I loved to suffer either. But Peter did not yet understand Jesus's promise. His love was real, but his advice was still wrong. That makes me want to be more careful about the advice I give and accept. Before encouraging someone to leave a difficult responsibility, I need to understand what that person has promised and what God has asked.

Jesus's prayer also helps me know how to pray when I am struggling. He told His Father how much He wanted the cup removed, and He remained willing to drink it. I can be honest with Father in Heaven about something I dread or wish were different. I can ask for relief and also ask for help to do what He requires of me. Being willing does not mean pretending it is easy.

Jesus kept His promise even when keeping it caused Him to tremble and bleed from every pore. Because He drank the cup, we can repent, rise from the grave, and return to the Father. When I need help keeping my own promises, I can turn to Him. He knows what it costs to keep a promise when it's hard.

◆ ◆ ◆

The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.